WHITE PAPER · VERSION 4.0

How Much Notice AI Vendors Give on Price and Model Changes

Every Notice Event We Track, June 2025 to October 2026

> Vendors rarely change prices. When they do, buyers get days, not months. Model retirements come with months of notice, and that notice has been getting shorter.

92
MEDIAN DAYS, RETIREMENTS (N = 39)

31.5
MEDIAN DAYS, INCREASES (N = 8)

27%
EVENTS WITH NO USABLE NOTICE (N = 70)

Jerry W. Lambert, Sr.

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Executive Summary

The AI price list is quieter than its reputation. Across every model we track, vendors changed a list price 0.36 times per model-year. Over the four months measured, 116 of 128 models held their list price. The trouble is in the timing and the gaps. When a price or billing term does change, it often lands in days. One in four changes arrives with no usable notice at all.

92 d
RETIREMENT MEDIAN, N = 39, CI 87 TO 180

31.5 d
INCREASE MEDIAN, N = 8, CI 3 TO 93

0 d
BOTH DATED PRICE CUTS, N = 2

0.36
PRICE CHANGES PER MODEL-YEAR, N = 128 MODELS

19 of 70
NO USABLE NOTICE, CI 17% TO 39%

-59.5%
MEDIAN FORCED-MIGRATION PRICE, N = 8

Seventy notice events make up the full population: 53 model retirements, 9 price increases, 3 price cuts and 5 new billing elements, announced between June 2025 and October 2026. Alongside them sit 113 model launches. Nothing was dropped. Events with no announcement date or no effective date stay in every count.

The data splits the usual story in two. Retirements are slow, scheduled and mostly generous. Price and billing changes are rare, fast and uneven. In a one-sided test, adverse price and billing changes got less notice than retirements ($p = 0.0026$). Sixty percent of them landed inside 30 days, against 10 percent of retirements.

What cuts the other way. Prices change rarely, and the rate is not rising. When a vendor forces a migration, the replacement usually costs less per token: six of eight measurable moves got cheaper. The case for buyers rests on surprise and missing notice, not on rising prices.

MY VIEW

Vendors are not raising prices every month. What the data shows is harder to plan for. A price change is rare, so nobody is watching for it, and when it comes it can take effect the same week. You can't budget around a change you only hear about after it hits the bill.

Retirements Get Months. Price Changes Get Days.

The type of change predicts the warning better than anything else in the data. A retirement is a project with a calendar. A price change is often a line in a changelog.

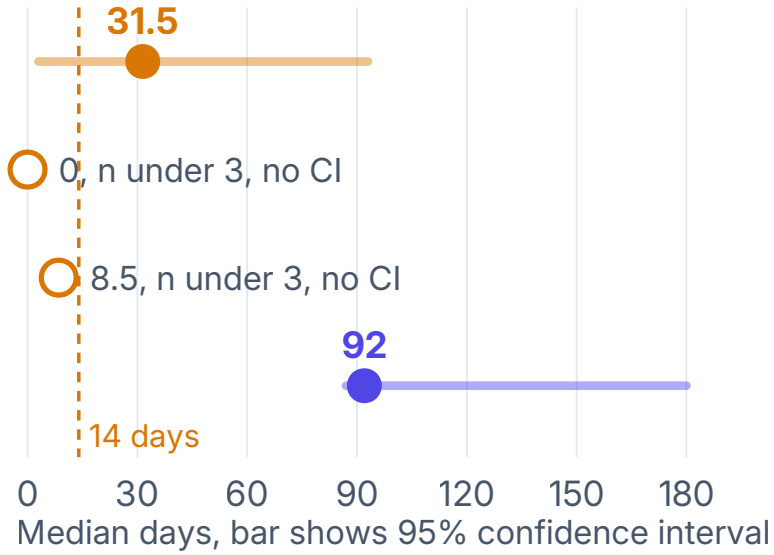
DAYS OF NOTICE BY CHANGE TYPE

Price increase
n = 8 with a date (9 total)

Price decrease
n = 2 with a date (3 total)

New billing element
n = 2 with a date (5 total)

Retirement
n = 39 with a date (53 total)



Notice is the effective date minus the announcement date, in calendar days. n counts events with both dates; the totals include events with a missing date. Medians use a percentile bootstrap with 10,000 resamples. No interval is shown where n is under 3.

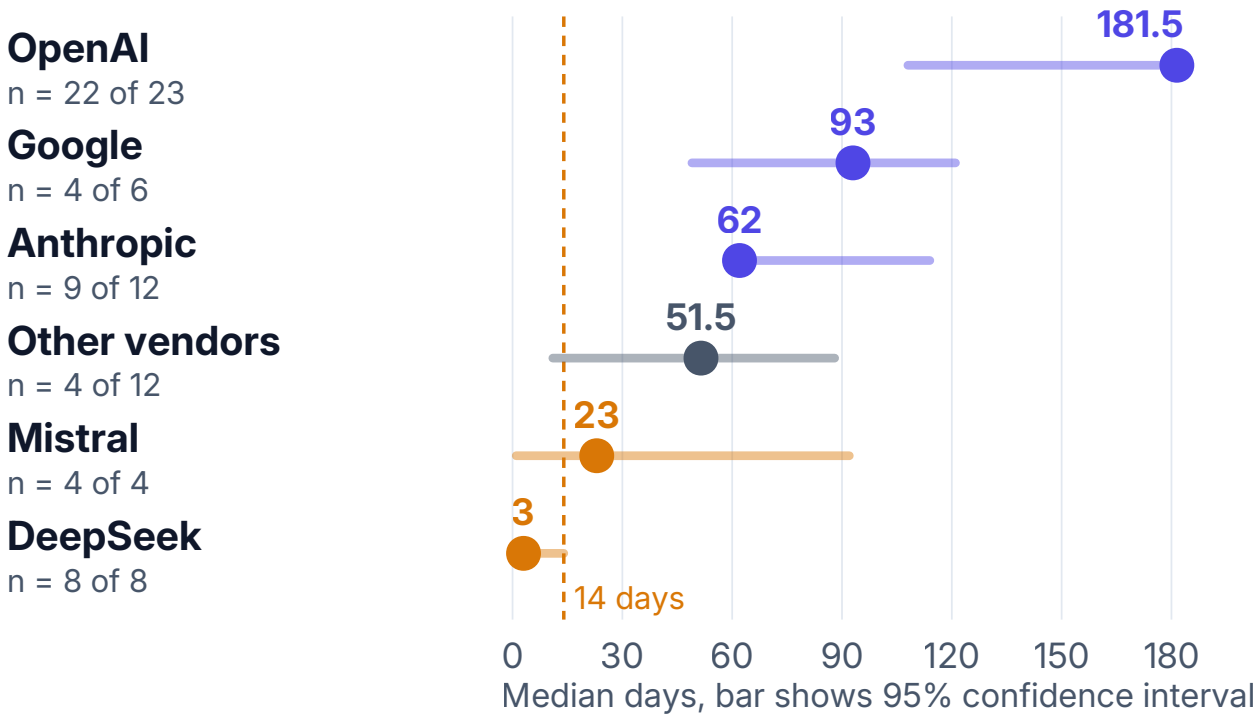
Retirements sit at a median of 92 days, and only 7.7 percent of them land inside two weeks. Price increases sit at 31.5 days, but half of them land inside 14. The two dated price cuts both took effect the day they were announced. That costs the buyer nothing on the invoice, but it means any forecast built on last week's price is already wrong.

New billing elements are the sharpest edge. Five appeared in the period. Two carry dates, at 3 and 14 days of notice. The other three have no effective date on record at all, so a buyer can't know when they started to apply.

Who You Buy From Sets Your Clock

Vendor policy explains most of the spread. The large vendors publish notice floors and mostly keep them. The smaller ones run on days.

MEDIAN DAYS OF NOTICE BY VENDOR



All change types combined. n is events with a usable notice figure out of each vendor's total. Vendors with fewer than four events are grouped as Other vendors (eight vendors, 12 events, 8 of them with no usable date). Moonshot's five events all lack a usable date, so it has no median and is not plotted.

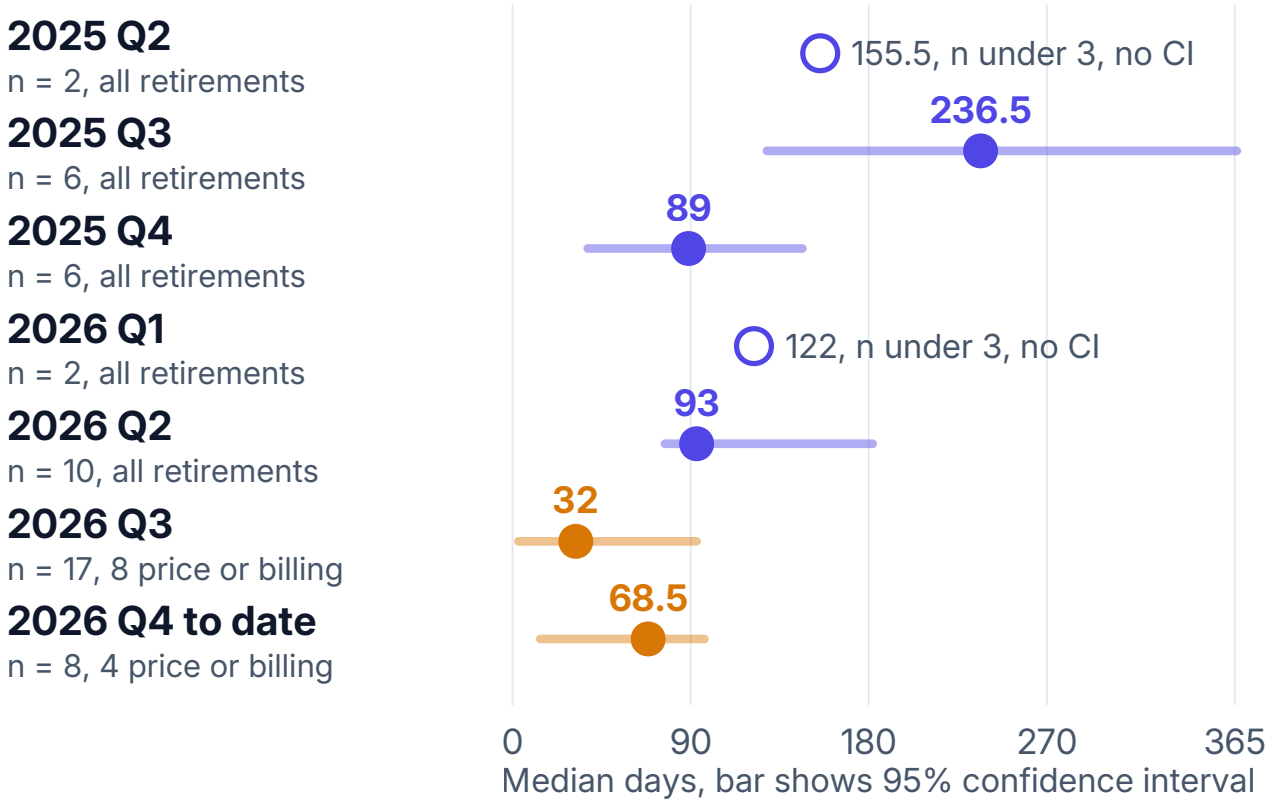
OpenAI gives the longest runway, a median of 181.5 days across 22 dated events, almost all retirements. Two of those 22 fell below its own stated 90-day floor for specialized variants, at 20 and 87 days. Anthropic clusters right at its stated 60-day floor and never went below it. Google's four price increases came with 49 to 121 days.

DeepSeek is the outlier. Its median is 3 days across 8 events, and 88 percent landed inside two weeks. Mistral sits at 23 days, with half its events under 14. For a buyer, the vendor mix is the notice policy.

Is Notice Getting Shorter?

Yes, on the full set. But the headline trend needs a warning label.

MEDIAN DAYS OF NOTICE BY ANNOUNCEMENT QUARTER



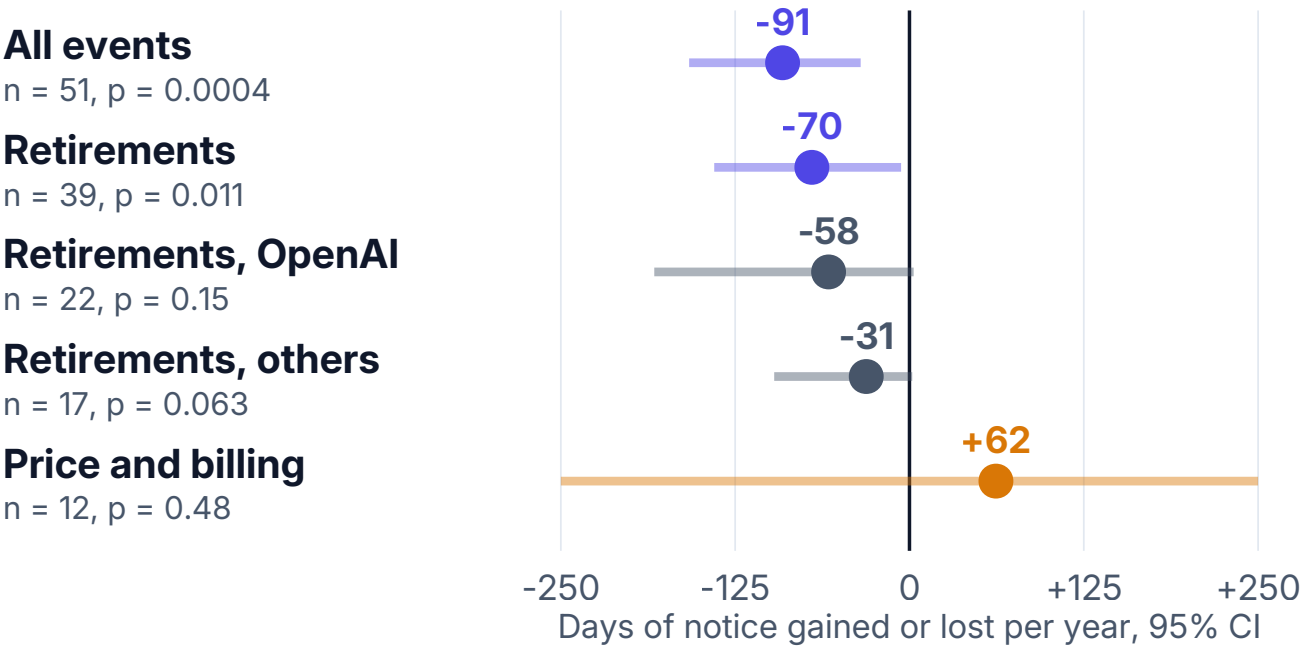
Medians with 95% bootstrap intervals. Quarters with fewer than three events show the median only. Orange marks quarters that include price and billing events.

Across all 51 events with a usable figure, notice falls as the announcement date moves forward (Kendall tau -0.35, p = 0.0004). The Theil-Sen slope is a loss of about 91 days of notice per year. The decline holds inside each vendor too: a model with vendor fixed effects gives -85 days per year (p = 0.0002).

Why the Trend Needs a Warning Label

The decline is real in aggregate. Split the events apart and most of the signal sits in retirements and in the change of mix.

HOW FAST NOTICE IS FALLING, BY SUBSET



Theil-Sen slopes. Mann-Kendall p-values on the left. The price and billing interval runs from -365 to +542 and is clipped at the chart edge.

> **The caveat.** Before mid-2026, every dated event in the record is a retirement. Price and billing events, which carry short notice, only enter from the third quarter of 2026. Part of the decline is that change in mix. Retirements alone still decline (p = 0.011), but the 2025 against 2026 split, 150.5 days against 92, is not significant (Mann-Whitney p = 0.13, n = 14 vs 22). Price and billing notice on its own shows no trend.

The honest reading is that retirement notice has slipped from roughly five months toward three, with wide error bars. Price and billing changes in the record come fast and show no trend. For a buyer the mix is what matters. In the second half of 2026, 12 of 25 notice events were short-clock price and billing changes.

Vendors Change Prices Rarely

This is the finding that cuts hardest against the churn story, and it belongs up front.

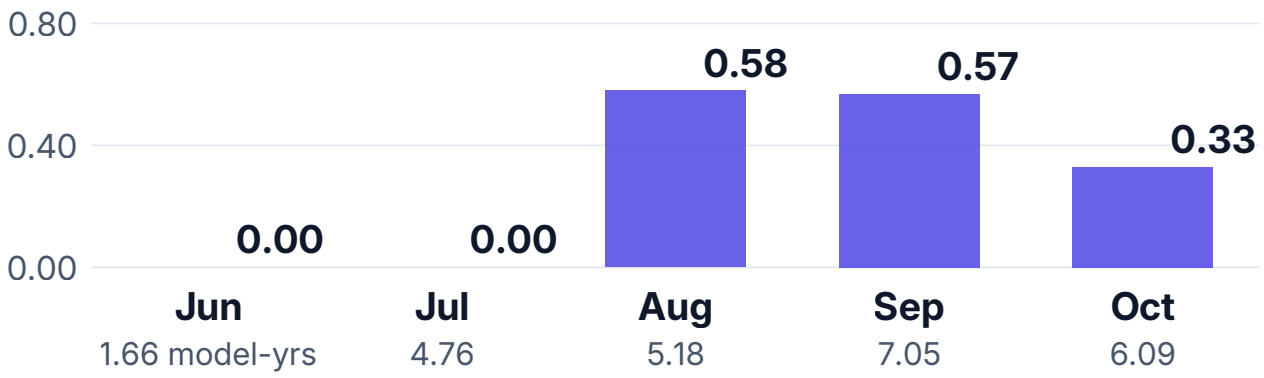
LIST PRICE CHANGES PER MODEL-YEAR, JUNE 19 TO OCTOBER 24, 2026



All 128 models with a price in force during the window, 25.3 model-years of exposure. Poisson exact 95% intervals. The 9 changes include 2 records of one announced increase that the vendor later cancelled.

Over four months, 12 of 128 models saw a vendor change their list price. Ten changed once and two changed twice. That works out to 0.36 changes per model-year (CI 0.16 to 0.68). A buyer running one model would expect a list price change about once every three years.

MONTHLY RATE OF PRICE CHANGES



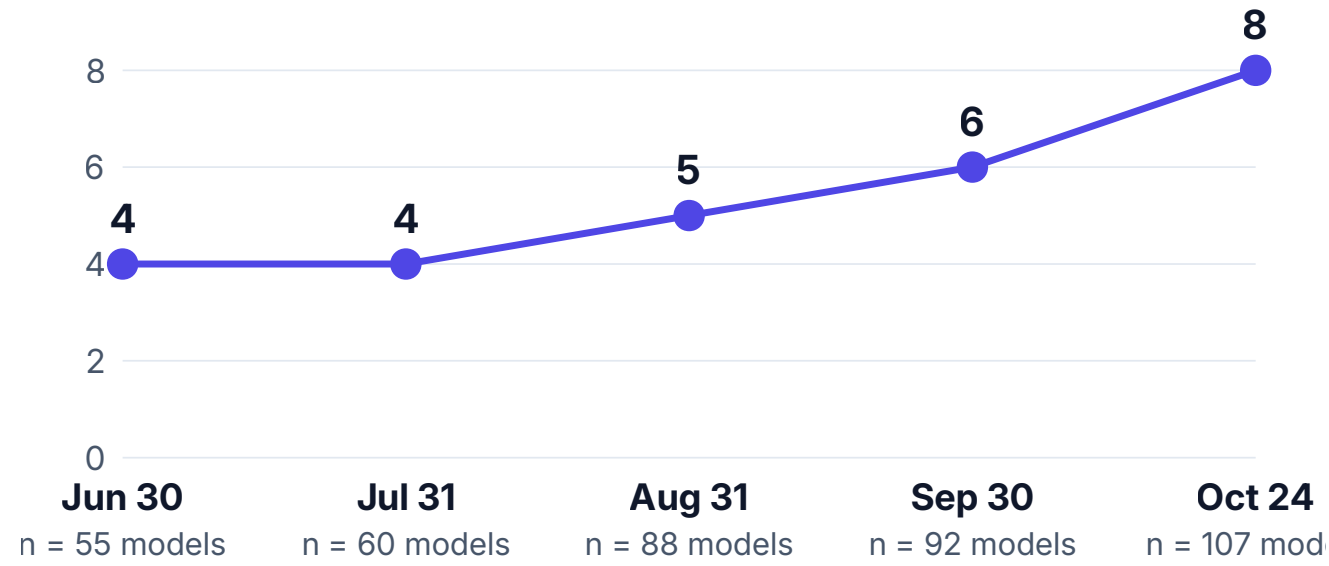
Changes per model-year by month, with model-years of exposure under each bar. Monthly counts are too small for useful intervals. Trend: Mann-Kendall tau +0.32, p = 0.45, n = 5 months.

The monthly rate shows no trend. Five more vendor changes are already scheduled after the window: four increases and one new fee.

The Bill Is Getting More Dimensions

Rates rarely move. The shape of the bill does.

DISTINCT BILLING ELEMENT TYPES IN FORCE



A count of every billing element type in force across all models on each date, so no interval applies. n is the number of models in force.

In June, every model billed on four elements: input, output, cache reads and cache writes. By late October there were eight. Long-context price bands now cover 22 models, and time-of-day bands cover 3. A per-request tool fee and a speed multiplier joined in October.

> **Read it carefully.** Only two of the four additions carry a vendor date. Time-of-day pricing came with 3 days of notice. The per-request tool fee came with 14. The other additions are older terms that became visible over the period, and three more billing terms have no announcement or effective date on record. Billing terms are hard to keep accurate even for people who watch them every day.

Each new element is another place a charge can differ from the price a buyer thinks applies. A long-context band changes the price of a request based on its length. A time-of-day band changes it based on the clock. Neither shows up in a headline per-token rate.

Forced Migrations Usually Cost Less

If the theory is that vendors retire cheap models to push buyers onto expensive ones, the data does not back it.

PRICE OF THE SUCCESSOR MODEL VS THE RETIRED ONE



lended price change, successor vs retired model, n = 8. Shaded band: 95% CI of the media

Blended at 3 parts input to 1 part output, list prices per million tokens. Of 53 retirements, 8 name a successor with a published price. Bootstrap 95% CI of the median: -74.0% to 0.0%.

Six of the eight measurable moves got cheaper, one stayed flat and one got dearer. The median change is -59.5 percent. The exception is large: one vendor retired a fast tier into a general model, and the per-token price rose 468 percent. Another successor's 55.6 percent cut is a launch price. After its scheduled step in January 2027 the saving shrinks to 11.1 percent.

So the cost of a forced migration is rarely the new rate. It is the move itself: testing a new model, rewriting prompts, checking outputs, on a date the vendor picks. Of the 53 retirements, 45 name no successor with a published price, which leaves the buyer to find one.

> **MY VIEW**
>
> Cheaper per token is not the same as cheaper. The bill falls only if the work moves on time and the new model does the job. When I only get two months, or two weeks, the price cut is the smallest part of the cost.

Scoring the Hypothesis

The claim under test: vendors are shortening notice and churning price terms, so buyers need an auditable record of every charge and the freedom to switch. Here is each piece against the data.

SUB-CLAIMS AND VERDICTS

Notice is getting shorter tau -0.35, p 0.0004, n = 51	Supported
Retirement notice is shrinking tau -0.29, p 0.011, n = 39	Weak
Price notice is shrinking tau +0.16, p 0.48, n = 12	Not supported
Price changes get less notice 60% vs 10% under 30 days, n = 10 vs 39	Supported
Price cuts arrive with no notice 2 of 2 dated cuts at 0 days	Supported
Vendors change prices often 0.36 per model-year, n = 128 models	Not supported
Price terms are multiplying 4 to 8 types, 2 with a vendor date	Partly
Buyers face forced moves 53 retirements; 27% of 70 with no usable notice	Supported

Trend tests are Mann-Kendall on notice against announcement date. The 30-day comparison is a one-sided Mann-Whitney test (p = 0.0026), with intervals of 26% to 88% and 3% to 24%. The no-notice share interval is 17% to 39%.

The half about notice holds. Notice is falling, price and billing changes get far less of it than retirements, and more than a quarter of all events have no usable date. The half about churn does not hold in its strong form. Prices are stable for most models, the rate is flat, and forced moves tend to save money per token.

What survives is narrower and more useful. The risk to a buyer is surprise. Changes are infrequent, they arrive on short or missing clocks, and they add new ways to be charged. Nineteen of 70 events carry no usable notice, and 12 have no effective date.

What This Means for Anyone Buying AI

A rare change with no warning is the hardest kind to catch. Nobody checks the invoice for a price they believe is fixed.

A Charge Record Nobody Can Rewrite

The answer to surprise is a record. Every charge should carry the model, the units, the price applied and the date of the Tariff it came from. That record should be immutable, so it can't be edited after the fact, and it should come with an attestation, a signed statement that it is complete and unchanged. With that in hand, a finance team can check any invoice line against the Tariff in force when the call ran, including the long-context and time-of-day bands a headline rate hides.

Billing terms are hard to keep accurate. Eight element types, changes that land in 0 to 14 days and events with no effective date make a strong case for proof over trust.

> **MY VIEW**
>
> I don't want to take the vendor's word for my bill, and I don't want to take my own spreadsheet's word either. I want every charge written once, signed and checkable.

The Freedom to Move Work

Fifty-three retirements in 17 months means forced moves are routine. The successor is often cheaper, but only for buyers who can move on the vendor's schedule. A buyer who can route work to another vendor without rewiring an application can take the cheaper option, sidestep a short clock and test a successor before the deadline. A buyer wired to one vendor takes whatever the next notice brings, on that vendor's terms.

For how many different ways AI gets billed today, see The 28 Ways AI Models Charge.

> **MY VIEW**
>
> It is a mistake for a consumer to lock themselves into one vendor.

Methodology. Figures come from vendors' public announcements made between June 10, 2025 and October 24, 2026: the full population of 70 notice events and 113 model launches we track, with no event left out.

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